

AN ANCIENT CHINESE ARMY

TERRACOTTA WARRIORS

Discovered near Mount Li in Shaanxi Province in 1974, the buried collection of sculptures known as the Terracotta Army opens a unique window on China's military past, providing a realistic representation of an army in the reign of self-styled "First Emperor" Qin Shi Huang over 2,000 years ago.

A towering figure in Chinese history, Qin Shi Huang unified all of China under his rule in 221 BCE, crushing his rivals by the relentless application of military power. As emperor he centralized power, suppressed dissent, and launched large-scale construction projects, including the first attempt to build a Great Wall to block the incursions of steppe nomads. The Terracotta Army was created as part of the emperor's burial complex: it comprises over 8,000 soldiers, 150 cavalry horses, and 130 chariots, each pulled by four horses.

The great majority of the army represented in these sculptures consists of peasant foot soldiers. They are depicted with armour of laced plates (the originals would have been made of bronze or hardened leather), and though helmets are not shown on the figures, archaeological finds of armour include them. The figures were also equipped with real weapons, fragments of which remain. Other sources reveal that infantrymen were equipped with a variety of bronze axes and swords, along with staff weapons, most typically the "dagger-axe". This was a long spear with a sharp blade attached to the haft, which could be used to stab in a prodding motion or wielded like a scythe. Many of the men also carried crossbows, a fundamental weapon in Chinese warfare: crossbows with sophisticated bronze trigger mechanisms were found during the excavation of the Terracotta Army.

Cavalry was a recent innovation that had helped Qin Shi Huang achieve his military ascendancy. With no native tradition of horsemanship, the Chinese had learned the importance

of mounted troops from their wars with steppe nomads; some of the horsemen would have been armed with varieties of bow. The chariots represented a Western influence on Chinese armies; by this period, rather than being used as a shock force, on the battlefield they chiefly functioned as mobile command platforms for aristocrats and senior officers, kept to the rear of the fighting troops. Indeed, officers in the Terracotta Army are portrayed as taller than ordinary soldiers, and are also identifiable by their long double tunics and more elaborate armour.

SERRIED RANKS

The arrangement of the Terracotta Army in ordered ranks suggests a body of disciplined soldiers drilled to march in step. According to ancient texts, armies numbering hundreds of thousands of men were fielded in the largest Chinese battles. Even allowing for exaggeration, the massed peasant forces must have been large and difficult to command. Banners were used to signal messages across the battlefield, drums marked an advance, and bells were sounded to order a retreat. Crossbows were probably deployed in mass formations, with soldiers shooting volleys in sequence, one group loosing their bolts while another reloaded. An exchange of missiles at distance was probably more to the taste of poorly motivated peasant conscripts than close-quarters combat. The emphasis in ancient military writings on deception, rather than pitched battles, may well reflect the difficulty of executing decisive battlefield manoeuvres with unwieldy forces.

